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Infinity, Ideality, Transcendentality: Derrida's Reading of the Idea in the Kantian Sense in Husserl

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Infinity, Ideality, Transcendentality: The Idea in the Kantian Sense in Husserl and Derrida

When Derrida translated and commented on Husserl's manuscript *The Origin of Geometry* in 1962, he gave a central place to what Husserl called the Idea "in the Kantian sense". This article reflects on the use and function of this Idea in Derrida's reading of Husserl. It critically interrogates the relationship between the Idea in the Kantian sense and mathematical ideality, as well as the use of this Idea in the interpretation of the thing (*Ding*) and the stream of experience (*Erlebnisstrom*). In the center of the discussion stands what Derrida calls "pure thinking", on which he tries to ground the Idea in the Kantian sense.

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1. Introduction

In the penultimate section (section X) of his "Introduction" to Husserl's *The Origin of Geometry*[1], Derrida assigns a central role to the Idea "in the Kantian sense". In Derrida's reading, the Idea in the Kantian sense becomes synonymous with a fundamental transformation of the phenomenal field that occurs when phenomenology becomes "transcendental" phenomenology. In this sense, Derrida remarks that Husserl's phenomenology

> locates the *space* where consciousness notifies itself of the Idea's prescription and thus is recognized as transcendental consciousness through the sign of the infinite […].[2]

What Derrida thereby means, I suppose, is that Husserl's phenomenology understands consciousness as standing under a certain "prescription", i.e., a law or a legislation, which is what gives to consciousness a "transcendental" meaning or character. Hence, transcendentality, in Derrida's sense, has to do with the imposition of a law and the exercise of a certain legal necessity. Furthermore, this "prescription", law or "de jure" character of transcendental consciousness, comes from nowhere else than from the "Idea", which, already in Husserl, is related to the "infinite". Hence, when consciousness is understood through the prism of the Idea in the Kantian sense, it not only integrates an

[1] This is the famous *Beilage III* of *Husserliana VI* (Husserl, *Crisis*, 353-378 (Appendice VI of the translation)) written by Husserl in 1936. The manuscript was originally published by Eugen Fink in 1939 under the title "Die Frage nach dem Ursprung der Geometrie als intentionalhistorisches Problem" in the *Revue Internationale de Philosophie*. Derrida published the translation and his long "Introduction" in 1962.

[2] Derrida, "Introduction", 154/140.

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infinite progression, but it thereby also acquires a *de jure* status from which it can legally dominate the phenomena that appear in its realm.

All this, I acknowledge, is not immediately understandable, even for an experienced reader of Husserl. The aim of this paper is therefore to shed some light upon the obscure terminological condensation between the Idea in the Kantian sense, the infinite, transcendental consciousness and its legal character.

Albeit the overt strangeness of Derrida's claims, it is not possible to simply ignore his interpretation and to leave it aside, uncommented. Even sixty years after its publication, Derrida's early reading of Husserl is still compelling. It is full of astonishingly accurate insights which betray an often-unprecedented understanding of Husserl's entire oeuvre. Derrida's reading of Husserl is not only attractive because of its provocative style, but also because of its capacity to constantly open new perspectives for seemingly old debates.

To untie the highly speculative nod that Derrida construes between consciousness, transcendentality and the Idea in the Kantian sense, we will have to follow Derrida's argument step by step, and verify each time the accuracy of his interpretations. Only in this way can we hope to identify the moment of Derrida's departure from Husserl, precisely when Derrida seeks to reduce the various occurrences of the Idea in the Kantian sense to one of it in particular, viz. to the mathematical ideality. Understanding the precise outline of this reduction will also provide insight about the underlying Cartesianism that guides Derrida's reading of Husserl. Just as Descartes claims an *intellectio*, i.e., a pure act of the understanding, as being involved in every performance of the soul, Derrida will himself impute to Husserl the omnipresence of a "pure thinking" (*penser pur*) which constitutively guides the infinite progression of all phenomenal givenness in the form of an Idea in the Kantian sense.

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The importance of the Idea in the Kantian sense is widely recognized in Husserlian scholarship and has been the subject of multiple studies[3]. This article seeks to extend these reflections and to apply them also to the study of Derrida's thinking. Not only will this be an opportunity to critically examine some phenomenological theses of the young Derrida, but we will also see how Derrida here lays the first milestones of his own critique of a "metaphysics of presence".

While studies on the Idea in the Kantian sense in Husserl's thought are solid and extensive, the same does not always hold for research on Derrida. Indeed, the few commentaries[4] that acknowledge the central role of such an Idea in Derrida's "Introduction" reduce its meaning to either a future temporalization[5] or to an operation of infinitization[6]. We will see that these two features are indeed absolutely important. But we will also understand that they only reveal their full meaning if we take into account what Derrida calls the "penser pur" (*pure thinking*), and which is characteristic for mathematical idealities. A refreshing exception to these shortcomings is a chapter from B. Hopkins, who rightly acknowledges that in Derrida's reading, "Husserl's

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[3] Carta, "On the distinction"; Tengelyi, "Experience and Infinity in Kant and Husserl", Welt und Unendlichkeit; Pradelle, Par-delà la révolution copernicienne; De Muralt, L'idée de la phénoménologie; Schuhmann, Die Fundamentalbetrachtung der Phänomenologie; Bernet, "Endlichkeit und Unendlichkeit in Husserls Phänomenologie.

[4] Most of the literature on Derrida's philosophy pays no attention to this notion: Gasché, The Train of Mirror. Derrida and the Philosophy of Reflection; Royle, Jacques Derrida; Stocker, Derrida on Deconstruction; Cazeaux, Metaphor and Continental Philosophy.

[5] DeRoo, Futurity in Phenomenology.

[6] Lawlor, Derrida and Husserl.

phenomenology can only be 'set up' on the basis of an Idea in the Kantian sense."[7] But since the aim of Hopkins is to provide an holistic overview of the Derrida's *Introduction*, it focus lies elsewhere and therefore misses to acknowledge the paradigmatic role of the "pure thinking" as well as the Cartesian undertone in Derrida's interpretation.

The structure of this paper's argument is as follows. After introducing, in a first step, the situation of the Idea in the Kantian sense in Husserl's work, the second, third and fourth moments of my argument will focus respectively on the application of the Idea in the Kantian sense to "exact" geometrical essences (part 2), to the thing (part 3) and to the stream of experience (part 4). Part 5 and 6 are dedicated to a critical discussion of Derrida's interpretation of Husserl (5) and to the analysis of a philosophical source of inspiration that could have motivated Derrida for his (*mis*)reading of Husserl (6).

2. Infinity, infinite tasks and the Idea in the Kantian sense

In his interpretation of modernity, Husserl makes abundantly use of the idea of the infinite (notably in the form of an infinite progress in scientific research)[8]. If modernity constitutes, in Husserl's eyes, an exceptional moment in the history of Western thought,

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[7] Hopkins, "Husserl and Derrida. On the Origin of Geometry", 68.

[8] It is important to notice that the mathematical theories that were important to Husserl were those of Bernard Bolzano and Georg Cantor, two mathematicians who both worked on infinity. As early as 1884/5, Husserl attended courses from Brentano on Bolzano's *Paradoxien des Unendlichen* (Schuhmann, *Husserl-Chronik*, 14), and Cantor's Theory of Manifolds occupies a central place in Husserl's epistemology, which he discusses in his *Prolegomena to a Pure Logic* as well as in *Formal and Transcendental Logic* (Cf. also: Hill, "La *Mannigfaltigkeitslehre* de Husserl").

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it is first of all because it grasps the idea of infinity and introduces it into mathematics (namely in the form of an infinite space)[9]. But infinity does not only transform mathematics, and in particular geometry: it also brings about an *ethical* transformation of the *geometer* themselves. For the geometer have to recognise that their own work is only relevant if they succeed in inserting it into a wider scientific community where their own role is that of "functionaries of mankind"[10]. The idea of the infinite concerns thus an ethical and destinal transformation of humanity itself[11] - a humanity which is now measured by the yardstick of an "infinite task"[12]. This "task" consists in the resolution of the "*enigma of enigmas*", i.e., the "world-problem": it concerns "the deepest essential interrelation between reason and what is in general"[13] (*die tiefste Wesensverbundenheit von Vernunft und Seiendem überhaupt*). Hence, in Husserl's view, the destinal telos of humanity aims at the perfect transposition of all being into knowing; it seeks to thematize all worldly reality at the level of its essence and thus as an ideality; it strives at the perfect symmetrisation between ontology and epistemology. Now, this, of course, is the telos of

[9] As M. Richir has shown, this transformation was not primarily brought about by Newton and his (theological) conception of an absolute space, but already by the thinking of the infinite in Nicolas de Cuse and Giordano Bruno (Rirchir, *La crise du sens et la phénoménologie*, 31).

[10] Husserl, *Crisis*, 15/17. Without making it explicit, Husserl takes up the conception of history of the Lumières, in particular of the Encyclopedists, Diderot and d'Alembert, who identify history with a process of accumulation of scientific knowledge, carried out collectively by the whole of humanity. (Diderot & d'Alembert, "Encyclopédie", 415.)

[11] Dastur, *Husserl*, 111.

[12] Husserl, *Crisis*, 19/21.

[13] *Ibid.*, 12/13.

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transcendental phenomenology, and it is, as we shall see, the Idea in the Kantian sense that is its bearer.

The relation between the Idea and the "infinite task" also makes the reference to Kant intelligible. It is indeed in Kant's regulating ideas of theoretical reason – and the "task" they are supposed to solve – that Husserl finds the first historical model of what he seeks to think at his own expense. In the *Critique of Pure Reason*, Kant mentions three ideas of theoretical reason (A 682/B 710 - A 685/B 713) which are said to be "regulative", since they regulate our infinite approximation to the organic unity of knowledge. When Husserl speaks of an Idea in the Kantian sense, he is referring to this possibility of regulating the infinite approximation of our knowledge towards its unification. Moreover, as with Kant, this unity is never that of an object, i.e., actual, realized, effective or closed. It is, on the contrary, the unity of what is aimed at in the future, i.e., simply projected; its status is eternally hypothetical.

Such an agreement between Husserl and Kant, however, takes shape against the background of a deeper disagreement. As D. Pradelle has shown, Kant's Ideas are necessary concepts of reason, that is, for Kant, of a *psychological* faculty[14]. They condition a metaphysical disposition in man to seek the unconditioned. They are therefore *noetic* structures and constrain the way in which man theorises nature (the world, herself, etc.). In Husserl, on the contrary, the concept of "reason" does not refer to a faculty of the soul[15]. It rather designates the course of validation and attestation necessary for the

[14] Pradelle, *Par-delà la révolution copernicienne*, 200. Kant's alleged psychologism is the most constant reproach that Husserl makes against Kant throughout his life-long reception of the philosopher from Königsberg (cf. Kern, *Husserl und Kant*).

[15] Husserl, Prolegomena, in: Logical Investigations, 216-217.

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recognition of a thing and the attribution of its corresponding ontological region; it designates a set of norms which legislate the different regions of being and which constrain the subject in her apprehension of things[16]. Now, just as his concept of reason, Husserl's Ideas in the Kantian sense are firmly situated in the domain of objects and are, therefore, *noematic* constraints for the intentional grasp of them. Furthermore, in contrast to Kant, Husserl's Ideas retain a fundamental relationship to *intuition*: while exceeding experience and projecting the unity of knowledge (or of the object) into a distant future, they are nevertheless structuring our intuition of things. This is an important remark for the following discussion. For the relationship to intuition is precisely what Derrida seeks to obliterate in his inquiry of the Ideas in the Kantian sense. In place of a survey of the different modes of intentional fulfilment that pertain to objects of different ontological reasons, Derrida indeed focuses on a "pure thinking", void of intuitive fulness, which he claims to be the common ground for all appearances in the phenomenological sense.

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3. "Exact" Essences as Ideas in the Kantian Sense

In his published works, the Idea in the Kantian sense first emerges in §74 of *Ideas* I, when Husserl distinguishes "descriptive" from "exact" sciences and essences. Descriptive sciences – including phenomenology – operate with "morphological" or "descriptive essences". These are themselves correlates of "morphological concepts of vague types of forms"[17]. Their particularity lies in their *inaccuracy*, i.e., in the fact that their sphere of

[16] Pradelle, Par-delà la révolution copernicienne, 203-211.

[17] Husserl, *Ideas,* I, 138/133.

application is fundamentally ”fluid”[18]. The term “fluid” refers to an indeterminacy that concerns not only the individuals who carry or ‘realise’ these essences, but these essences themselves as well as their corresponding concepts.

Where does this “inexactness” come from? Curiously, it is not due to a lack or defect of intuition – as if it could be made up by a better gaze or a closer view. On the contrary, morphological essences are inexact, *because we can have an intuition of them*. According to Husserl, they belong to the “sphere of imaginative ideas” or, more simply, to the “sphere of imagination”[19]. Everything that belongs to this sphere has only ‘typical’ generality. This is precisely what distinguishes morphological essences from exact essences.

Exact essences are always a matter of thought and can never be intuited. Their thinking is about something that, in essence, cannot be seen. While morphological essences, such as ‘colour’, ‘roundness’ or ‘perception’, are adequately instantiated in sensible objects, exact essences correspond to nothing that can be given in sensible perception. Taken in their Euclidean mathematical meaning, a ‘point’, ‘line’ or a ‘circle’, cannot be encountered in the world. They constitute “ideal limits” (*exakte Limesgestalten*) to which sensible objects can only be *more or less* approximated. This is why exact sciences – and first of all geometry – think in terms of “ideal concepts” (*Idealbegriffe*) or “exact

[18] Husserl, *Ideas,* I, 138/133.

[19] Husserl, *Ideen*, III, 133.

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concepts" (*exakte Begriffe*), which, as Husserl says, "transcend intuition in methods of idealisation"[20],[21].

It is precisely for being such an unreachable limit for all intuition, that Husserl calls geometrical essences "Ideas in the Kantian sense". As he says in *Ideas*, I: "Exact concepts have their correlates in essences that have the character of '*ideas*' *in the Kantian sense*."[22] This is the moment when Derrida's "Interpretation" makes its first important incision: for the exactitude of the geometric essence requires what he calls a "pure thinking":

> Unlike morphological ideality, exact ideality has been produced without the essential aid of sensibility of imagination; it broke away by a leap from every descriptive mooring. […] It is 'pure thinking' that is responsible for the leaping advance of idealization and for geometrical truth as such.[23]

Geometric idealities are, as Derrida says, the result of a "pure thinking". Their "exact" identity with themselves is fundamentally dependent upon their confirmation by thought. In other words, exact essences can only be thought and never intuited.[24] Their

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[20] Husserl, *Natur und Geist*, 219.

[21] In contrast to Kant, where geometric forms depend on the construction of a concept in intuition (Anderson, *The Poverty of Conceptual Truth*), in Husserl, geometric concepts are what is fundamentally non-intuitionable – their non-intuitionability guarantees their correctness.

[22] Husserl, *Ideas,* I, 138/133.

[23]Derrida, "Introduction", 145/133.

[24] In underlining the intellectual character of the apprehension of mathematical idealities, Derrida anticipates a series of phenomenologically inspired French epistemologists, such as Jean-Toussaint Desanti (*Les Idéalités mathématiques*), Maurice Caveign (*Le problème des objets dans la pensée mathématique*), and most recently, Dominique Pradelle (*Intuition et Idealités*). These thinkers claim the *intratheoretical* character of mathematical objects for which a direct,

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characterization as Ideas in the Kantian sense therefore hinges on the fundamental fact that they imply an asymptotic approximation to an ideal of exactness that excludes intuition and requires a radical "leap" beyond it.

Let us underline that Derrida's reading of Husserl is in this point absolutely correct. The problem, as we will see shortly, concerns not his interpretation of mathematical idealities and the role of the Idea in the Kantian sense in them. It consists, on the contrary, in the way in which Derrida uses mathematical idealities for understanding all other occurrences of the Idea in the Kantian sense.

4. The Thing as an Idea in the Kantian Sense

Husserl mobilises the idea in the Kantian sense not only in the description of geometrical idealities, but also in his analyses of the stream of experiences (*Erlebnisstrom*) as well as of the thing. But neither the *Erlebnisstrom* nor the thing are exact essences! Their essences are, on the contrary, inexact, that is, morphological. What does an Idea in the Kantian sense mean in these contexts? Can we assume that it is still about the same Idea? Unfortunately, Husserl says nothing about this issue. Derrida seems to have identified the problem. He writes: "The Idea in the Kantian sense, the regulative pole for every infinite task, assumes diverse but analogous functions that are decisive at several points along Husserl's itinerary."[25] How does Derrida resolve the diversity of "functions" of the Idea in the Kantian sense?

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intuitive donation on the model of sensible intuition is categorically excluded. Against Husserl, they claim that the mathematical object is dependent on logical demonstrations based on axioms and that it cannot exist outside of such a theoretical and nomological framework.

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The thing is obviously not a geometrical essence. The infinite openness discovered in it does not imply an asymptotic progression towards exact determination. The thing is indeed the very opposite of exactness. Furthermore, there is a fundamental difference in the kind of temporal/historical progression that is involved in the geometrical essence, on the one hand, and the thing, on the other. Although the factual moment of the discovery of a mathematical ideality (or features of it) pertains to the contingency of empirical history (it could have been someone else than Pythagoras who discovered the Pythagorean theorem), the realm of mathematical possibilities itself is fully determined in advance. Mathematical idealities are based on a finite system of fundamental axioms and these axioms contain a priori the set of features that can be deduced from them.

Mathematical idealities are therefore *anticipatable by law*, whereas the temporal progression of the thing confronts us with the non-anticipatable. In fact, it implies a fundamental instability. We cannot stress enough this form of an indefinite progression that strikes the thing with *contingency* and threatens it with always becoming something else. Husserl elaborates this at length in his famous 1907 lecture on *Thing and Space*. This lecture is absolutely crucial for the Husserlian theory of perception, since Husserl here dismisses the possibility of an adequate donation of the 'transcendent' thing. Not only is its full determination an "infinite task", but this task is constantly in danger of turning into an "aimless undertaking"[26] (*zielloses Unternehmen*), i.e., a contingent, irrational and a-teleological investigation.

We here see rising a fundamental opposition between the thing's contingency and geometry's necessity. Curiously, Derrida is not at all denying this fundamental difference.

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[25] Derrida, "Introduction", 150/153.

[26] Husserl, *Thing and Space*, 138/114.

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On the contrary, he acknowledges that the thing constantly and principally escapes us, whereas the development of mathematical objects, as he says, "will never *de jure* escape us."[27] Despite acknowledging this difference, Derrida claims nevertheless the proximity between the thing and the mathematical essence. And what is even more complicated is the fact that he is able to ground his claim on an insight of Husserl, who himself argues for a certain *necessity inherent in the thing* – precisely insofar as the thing is understood *as an Idea in the Kantian sense*!

To understand this point, it is helpful to have a look at a manuscript from 1909, which is the first trace of the Idea in the Kantian sense in Husserl's unpublished works (written 2 years after Husserl's lecture on *Thing and Space*[28]). In this manuscript, Husserl opposes two conceptions of nature, that of Kant and that of himself. To set up this opposition, he refers to two kinds of ideas: Kant's Idea of nature, on the one hand, and his own Idea of nature, on the other, which he calls 'Idea in the Kantian sense'. Reflecting on the thing's infinite series of adumbrations, Husserl notes:

> This does not mean that the 'course of nature' (or the flow of absolute consciousness) must be determined in advance; but [...] that the form of nature, the framework, so to speak, which is filled by ever-new facticity, is absolutely determined (*absolut feststeht*).

[27] Derrida, "Introduction", 148/136.

[28] The introduction of the Idea in the Kantian sense in 1909 anticipates Husserl's renewed interest for mathematical infinity (in the form of Cantor's transfinite), which Tengelyi dates around 1910 (Tengelyi, *Welt und Unendlichkeit*, 534). Tengelyi explains this interest by the success of Ernst Zermelo who, in 1908, provided an axiomatic foundation for Cantor's set theory.

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> At least one could be content with this, although it is less than Kant's Idea of nature. Thus, then, empirical truth, consequently also the being of nature, is an Idea in Kant's sense.[29]

Husserl acknowledges that his own conception of nature involves "less" a priori knowledge than the one of Kant. But he argues that his own conception of nature is not completely void of a priori knowledge. In particular, he underlines that the "form" of nature is a priori *determined*. Hence, from its first introduction into the phenomenological field in 1909, the Idea in the Kantian sense is supposed to express an a priori certainty with respect to the infinite course of nature; it is supposed to re-institute the a priori power of the subject vis-à-vis what it apprehends as an infinite flow of adumbrations; it gives the subject the possibility of anticipating what cannot be anticipated.

In 1913 and the *Ideas*, I, Husserl discusses at length the consequences that the introduction of such an idea entails. First of all, he claims a fundamental difference between the infinite on the one hand, and the a priori rule of this infinite, on the other. The Idea in the Kantian sense is only identified with the *rule of the infinite*, not with the infinite itself. As Husserl points out in § 143: "The idea of an essentially motivated infinity is not itself an infinity [...]."[30] The Idea makes the infinite progression of the thing

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[29] Husserl, Ms. D 13 II/146: "Das besagt nicht, dass im Voraus der 'Gang der Natur' durchaus (bzw. der Fluss des absoluten Bewusstseins) bestimmt sein müsste; aber wohl […] dass zugleich die Form der Natur, der Rahmen sozusagen, der durch die immer neue Faktizität ausgefüllt wird, absolut feststeht. Wenigstens könnte man sich damit begnügen, obschon es weniger ist als Kants Idee der Natur. So ist denn die empirische Wahrheit, folglich auch das Sein der Natur eine Idee in Kantischem Sinne." (I express my gratitude to the director of the Husserl Archives in Leuven, Prof. J. Jansen, for her permission to quote from Husserl's unpublished manuscripts.)

[30] Husserl, *Ideas*, I, 331/285.

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finite, since it anticipates the "form", "framework" or "rule" of its total unfolding. It finitises the infinite of the thing and makes its unity conceivable – if not in intuition, at least, as Derrida will say, "in thought".

This point goes not unremarked by Derrida, who exploits it in order to interpret the Idea of the thing in the same terms as the geometrical essence. For Derrida, hence, the Idea of the thing and its total deployment becomes a givenness for *pure thinking*, that is to say a givenness that refuses all intuition: "It [the Idea in the Kantian sense] is evidence only insofar as it is *finite*, i.e., here, *formal*, since the content of the infinite *Idea* is absent and is denied to every intuition."[31] According to Derrida, the Idea in the Kantian sense transposes into a *de jure* phenomenon what is experienced as an imposition and contingency of fact. It anticipates – by means of a *pure thinking* – what is concretely intuited as an indefinite infinity of adumbrations.

5. The Stream of Consciousness as an Idea in the Kantian Sense

The element of pure thinking is also crucial for Derrida's reading of the third occurrence of the Idea in the Kantian sense in *Ideas*, I: the stream of consciousness, outlined in § 84. Husserl here highlights the fact that the *Erlebnisstrom* constitutes the "*primordial form of consciousness*"[32]. This means that every donation for consciousness, whether noematic or noetic, must necessarily be able to satisfy this form: everything must be able to be inserted into this flow of experiences which is itself structured by a twofold infinite progression, that of an infinite retreat into the past and an infinite advancement towards

[31] Derrida, "Introduction", 153/139.

[32] E. Husserl, *Ideas*, I, 185/159.

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the future. What interests Husserl in the discussion of the *Erlebnisstrom*, however, is less the temporal distribution of experiences according to the before and after, but rather the *mode of givenness* within this distribution. He therefore uses the metaphor of the horizon:

> Talk of the *experiential horizon* here means, however, not only the horizon of phenomenological temporality in terms of its described dimensions but also differences of *new kinds of* modes of givenness.[33]

Within the total phenomenon of the *Erlebnisstrom*, past and future are *non-adequate* data that can never be exchanged into adequate ones. Again, the Idea in the Kantian sense intervenes here precisely to sign the possibility of a non-adequate and implicit donation of past and future which, although non-adequate, do not cease to be a true (and even necessary) donation:

> It is precisely the distinctive character of the idea-forming process of discerning a Kantian idea that does not somehow forfeit a patent discernibility (*Einsichtigkeit*), on account of the fact that determining its content adequately (here, the stream of experience) is unattainable.[34]

In the context of the *Erlebnisstrom*, the Idea in the Kantian sense thus refers to the necessary non-intuitive relationship to past and future experiences. The *Erlebnisstrom*

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[33] *Ibid.*, 166/159.

[34] *Ibid.*, 166/160. Since the sentence is grammatically complex, I also quote the German original: "Es ist eben das Eigentümliche der eine Kantische ‚Idee' erschauenden Ideation, die darum nicht etwa die Einsichtigkeit einbüßt, dass die adäquate Bestimmung ihres Inhaltes, hier des Erlebnisstromes unerreichbar ist."

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retains an "Einsichtigkeit" with respect to past and future while refusing their adequate intuition. Hence, it is true that the Idea in the Kantian sense allows the phenomenologist to operate with non-transparent and inadequate data. But does this automatically mean what Derrida seeks to establish, viz, that the *Erlebnisstrom* simply operates with *thought experiences*, meant in the absence of their fulfilment? This is indeed what Derrida is suggesting, and this is also what motivates him to bring the *Erlebnisstrom* closer to the geometric essence:

> The unity of infinity, the condition for that temporalization, must then be *thought*, since it is announced without appearing and without being contained in a Present. This thought unity, which makes the phenomenalization of time as such possible, is therefore always the Idea in the Kantian sense which never phenomenalizes itself. […] Are not the Idea and the idealizing ability, which exemplarily occupy us here as the origin of mathematics (*l'origine du mathematique*), kept back in this essential darkness?[35]

For Husserl, the *Erlebnisstrom*, understood as an Idea in the Kantian sense, implies a necessary non-adequacy of the phenomena that are revealed in it. Derrida jumps on this insight, but clearly overturns it. For as we saw, this necessary non-adequacy leads him to the claim that the *Erlebnisstrom* originates in the same source as 'the mathematical'. And this source is, again, a "pure thinking", i.e., what Husserl calls, echoing Brentano, an *uneigentliches Denken*, an inauthentic or merely symbolic thinking[36].

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[35] Derrida, "Introduction", 150/137.

[36] DeRoo correctly identifies the central role of the idea in the Kantian sense in the integration of non-adequate elements into the phenomenological field (DeRoo, *Futurity in Phenomenology*, 109). But he fails to grasp the intrinsic link, in Derrida's interpretation, between non-adequate givenness and "pure thinking",

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We finally understand the centrality of the Idea in the Kantian sense in Derrida's reading. For with such an Idea, something is given in thought that does not appear – and that principally cannot appear. This non-appearance, however, is not simply the absence of a phenomenon, but the *pure imposition of a law* which regulates all phenomenal givenness. It is the law itself, the *teleological legislation* of phenomena, which is incapable of adequate donation. Derrida says:

> Thus, for once, nothing appears in a specific evidence. What does appear is only the regulative possibility of appearing and the finite certainty of infinite phenomenological determinability, i.e., a certainty without corresponding evidence.[37]

6. Critical Discussion of Derrida's Interpretation

Now that we have understood the main strategy of Derrida's use of the Idea in the Kantian sense, we need to verify the solidity of his interpretation of Husserl.

First of all, Derrida conflates the *inadequate* givenness of transcendent objects with the *purely intellectual* apprehension of mathematical idealities. He does not seem to acknowledge the decisive fact that *transcendent objects can only be given inadequately*[38], which is to say that only segments of such objects can be originally intuited: the rest is necessarily apprehended in an inauthentic manner. In order to grasp the totality of the

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as well as Derrida's overall strategy, which seeks to ground the phenomenological field on such a "pure thinking".

[37] Derrida, "Introduction", 153/139.

[38] Husserl, *Ideas*, I, 91/78.

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thing's determinations, we have to engage in a perceptual synthesis that can only unfold progressively. This does not mean, however, that transcendent objects lack original self-givenness altogether. On the contrary, in his lecture on *Thing and Space*, Husserl underlines that "the [transcendent] object stands in perception as there in the flesh (*leibhaftig*), it stands […] as actually present, as self-given there in the current now."[39] *Transcendent objects are originally given* – they *do have* the character of "*Leibhaftigkeit*"[40]. But their givenness is always embedded in the complex context of various intentional acts which imply both empty and fulfilling intentions. Expressed noematically, this means that there is always "necessarily a *core of 'what is actually displayed,'* surrounded […] by a *horizon of 'what is cogiven*"[41].

This contrasts radically with mathematical idealities, which lack every kind of original givenness whatsoever. Furthermore, it is totally wrong to say that the non-given parts of the transcendent object are merely apprehended in thought. For they are always anticipated in a certain way, i.e., according to "*a firmly prescribed style*" [42]; and this style is coherent to the original givenness[43]. Original givenness and *Leibhaftigkeit* are thus essential moments of transcendent objects – while they completely lack in the case of

[39] Husserl, *Thing and Space*, 14/12.

[40] Husserl, *Ideas*, I, 315/271.

[41] Husserl, *Ideas*, I, 91/77.

[42] Husserl, *Ideas*, I, 91/77.

[43] As D. Lohmar showed, the apprehension of non-given parts of the transcendent object does not rely on pure thinking, but on a certain kind of productive phantasy, which has a certain degree of quasi-perceptual fulness (Lohmar, *Phänomenologie der schwachen Phantasie*).

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mathematical idealities. It is thus incorrect to identify both on the basis of an allegedly shared "pure thinking", as Derrida does.

Another problem, which is still related to this first point: Derrida overlooks the decisive fact that the Idea in the Kantian sense designates something fundamentally different in all the three contexts mentioned in *Ideas,* I. As E. Carta recently showed[44], the *Erlebnisstrom* and the thing are *given* in the form of an Idea in the Kantian sense, whereas mathematical idealities only "have the character"[45] of such Ideas. For being 'transcendent' objects, the *Erlebnisstrom*[46] and the thing both have a certain determinate way of original givenness, and the Idea in the Kantian sense describes this specific style of givenness: they appear in intuition according to a teleological progression, and the Idea in the Kantian sense is the form of this progression.

This strongly contrasts with mathematical idealities, which are not 'sketched' or 'displayed' according to such an Idea. As we saw, they depend upon a 'leap' beyond the sphere of original intuition. Their apprehension requires a "passage to the limit", i.e., an asymptotic approximation which prepares the 'leap' beyond the realm of all morphological forms. Hence, in the case of exact essences, the Idea in the Kantian sense structures the approximation, the Limes-character, and not the ideality itself. This is probably what Husserl meant when he said that mathematical objects are not "given" in the form of an Idea, but only "have the character" of it.

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[44] Carta, "On the distinction".

[45] Husserl, *Ideas*, I, 139/133.

[46] Carta refers to a passage of Husserl's *Lectures on Passive Synthesis* (204/256), where Husserl says that the *Erlebnisstrom* is the "first transcendence".

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Furthermore, in a manuscript from the early 1920', Husserl clearly negates what Derrida's interpretation implicitly assumes: that the givenness of a transcendent object has the character of a *Limes*[47]. According to Husserl, the indeterminate progression of an infinite sequence of adumbrations *cannot* be understood in terms of an asymptotic approximation towards the thing, because the thing itself is originally given in this sequence.

Another problem of Derrida's reading concerns the pervasive reference to a "pure thinking", which he understands as being involved in every kind of phenomenological appearing. What exactly is "pure thinking"? The expression of "pure thinking" recalls the Cartesian *intellectio*, that Husserl himself discusses in the context of mathematics. Husserl indeed recognizes the validity of such an "*intellectio*", that he defines as the "intellectual thought-processes of geometry", in which "the idea of a geometrical figure is constituted"[48]. But it remains clear to Husserl that such an *intellectio* is a highly particular form of intentional act, which must not be generalized and applied to regions other than mathematical idealities. On the contrary, Husserl's phenomenological epistemology is based on the assumption of a *plurality* of essentially different regions of objects, which all have their own rationality, their own forms of intentional constitution and validation[49]. Hence, for Husserl, the *intellectio* is only a local and regional intentional mode alongside a series of other spiritual activities, such as feeling, perceiving or willing.

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[47] Husserl, Zur Lehre vom Wesen und zur Methode der eidetischen Variation, 81.

[48] Husserl, Logical Investigations, 70/208.

[49] For instance, Husserl, *Ideen*, III, 36: "Im Wesen des originär gebenden Bewusstseins überhaupt gründen kardinale Scheidungen nach Grundarten, die systematisch aufzusuchen und wissenschaftlich zu beschreiben eine der vornehmsten Aufgaben der Phänomenologie ist. Jeder solchen Grundart entspricht offenbar ein regionaler Begriff, der die Sinnesform der

In sum, Derrida's interpretation of phenomenology imputes to Husserl a form of Cartesian rationalism that is hardly defensible. It betrays Derrida's own commitment to Descartes and the Cartesian interpretation of the *intellectio*. For Descartes (and not for Husserl), the *intellectio* is virtually present in *every* performance of the soul[50], precisely insofar as the soul aims at something objective: the *intellectio* refers to nothing else than to the presence of the mind towards its object. As early as in his *Regulae*, Descartes equates the "*intellectus purus*" with "the power through which we know things"[51]. And he describes the *intellectus purus* as:

> one single power, which either receives figures from the common sense at the same time as does the fantasy (*phantasia*), or applies itself to those which are preserved in the memory, or forms new ones […], or transfers them to the motive force in accordance with the disposition of the pure body.[52]

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jeweiligen Grundart gebender Anschauung umgrenzt, und entspricht in weiterer Folge eine Gegenstandsregion, alle Gegenstände umspannend, denen dieser Sinn zugeeignet ist." Cf. also Pradelle, *Par-delà la révolution copernicienne*, 208.

[50] This is clearly expressed by Martial Guéroult in his influential work *Descartes selon l'ordre des raisons*, 77: "l'intellect pur est présent dans tous les modes de la pensée, même dans ceux qui lui sont le plus étrangers comme l'imagination, le sentiment, la volonté, car ces modes doivent être nécessairement rapportés à la '*substance intelligente*' du fait qu'ils enferment quelque sorte d'intellection."

[51] Descarte, *Regulae*, 144f.

[52] Ibid.

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As said, Husserl's phenomenological epistemology fiercely rejects such a generalization of the intellectual power. Derrida's pervasive use of the "pure thinking" therefore seems to mistake Husserl with Descartes; it finally interprets Husserl in the same way as Husserl himself interprets Galileo, i.e., as a physicist and a reductionist, who claims that all phenomena ultimately rest upon a mathematical manifold that can only be apprehended by a purely intellectual power[53].

But if not to Husserl, Derrida's interpretation fits at least very well in the context of his own later view on phenomenology, which it indeed prepares and inaugurates. As is well known, in *La voix et le phénomène*, Derrida highlights two conflicting tendencies which seem to go parallel in Husserl's phenomenology: one the one hand, Husserl's inclination to purify the phenomenological field and to reduce it to pure idealities of meaning, present to the mind in a methodologically required soliloquy, without factual expression; on the other hand, the constant thematisation of various forms of opacities and absences which principally resist any attempt to render them present, but which nevertheless structure the phenomenological field (such as, time, memory and the other). How fits Derrida's interpretation of the Idea in the Kantian sense to this later framework?

Rudolf Bernet, one of the rare commentators who rightly acknowledges the centrality of the Idea in the Kantian sense in Derrida's "Introduction", sees in it an early critique against Husserl's "phenomenological intuitionism"[54]. He understands Derrida's interpretation of the Idea in the Kantian sense as an expression of "the consequent impossibility of encompassing the ground of phenomenology itself"[55], and thus as a

[53] Brunschvig, "Husserlian Perspectives on Galilean Physics", 34.

[54] Bernet, "On Derrida's 'Introduction' to Husserl's *Origin of Geometry*", 145.

[55] Ibid.

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conceptual device to dismantle Husserl's "metaphysics of presence". In consideration of the central role of the "pure thinking" in Derrida's understanding of the Idea, I do not think that this interpretation is correct. Seen as a function of the Cartesian *intellectio*, the Idea in the Kantian sense cannot be used as a critical device against Husserl's "metaphysics of presence". It rather suggests the inverse association, for it brings phenomenology closer to an illusionary but principle self-presence of the thinking mind; it therefore appears as the highest expression of such a "metaphysics of presence"[56], and not as a critique against it.

7. De Muralt on Husserl's 'Exemplarism': A Forgotten Source of Inspiration?

Derrida's interpretation clearly pushes Husserlian thought into a rationalist direction which can hardly be corroborated. What could have been Derrida's intellectual motivation for engaging into such a reading? A first explanation might be the generalized Cartesianism in which the young Derrida was immersed during his studies[57]. Another,

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[56] My reading of the "pure thinking" in Derrida therefore rather supports L. Lawlor's interpretation of the mathematical object as being "the source of Derrida's concept of presence, being as presence […]." (Lawlor, *Derrida and Husserl*, 105) The paradox is, however, that the theoretical core of this presence is not to be found in intuition, but rather in pure thinking.

[57] From 1952 to 1956, Derrida studied at the *Ecole Normale Supérieure* de Paris. In 1950 was published the second edition of Jean Laporte's *Rationalisme de Descartes*, and in 1953 Martial Gueroult published the two volumes of his important book *Descartes selon l'ordre des raisons*. During the time of Derrida's studies at the ENS, Gueroult lectured at the Collège de France (1951-1962), just some blocks away from the ENS. As a philosophy student in Paris at this time, it was impossible not to know these important interpretations of Descartes.

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reason might have been, I claim, Derrida's reading of André de Muralt, whose book, *The Idea of Phenomenology. Husserl's Exemplarism*, he quotes in his "Introduction"[58]. De Muralt defends a Neoplatonic interpretation of Husserl in which the Idea in the Kantian sense appears as a phenomenological core-concept. De Muralt's interpretation relies on two fundamental claims (which we can today identify as errors): (a) the identification of the phenomenological eidos (or essence) with an ideal limit-form (*ideale Limesgestalt*); (b) the identification between phenomenological transcendentalism and the infinitization of phenomena. As we saw, these two claims also guide Derrida's own reading. We therefore have good reason to think that, while writing his "Introduction", Derrida was under the influence of De Muralt (although De Muralt is only mentioned once). Let us quickly assess in what De Muralt's two claims consist and why they are unacceptable.

(a) What De Muralt calls Husserl's "exemplarism" amounts to the view that all individuals are factitious examples of their corresponding universal idea, which is their ideal copy or eidos: "the idea is *form*, i.e., *essence"*, and De Muralt continues: "This is the nerve of *Husserlian exemplarism: the essence is norm* or *form is exemplary*."[59]

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Furthermore, in 1963, just one year after the publication of his "Introduction", Derrida presents his impressive answer to Foucault's *Histoire de la folie* under the title "Cogito et histoire de la folie", in which he provides a proof of his precise and holistic knowledge of Descartes' philosophy.

[58] Derrida, "Introduction", 58/68.

[59] De Muralt, *L'idée de la phénoménologie*, 26: "Or, l'idée est forme, c'est-à-dire essence. C'est ici le nerf de l'exemplarisme husserlien : l'essence est norme ou la forme est exemplaire."

According to De Muralt, things tend teleologically toward the realisation of their "idea", which constitutes their ideal and unreachable limit[60].

Now, as we have seen, the idea of a limit (*Limes* or *Grenze*) belongs properly to *exact* essences and has nothing to do with morphological essences. In the domain of the latter, it is not clear at all what such a limit could consist of. For the idea of an asymptotic approximation makes only sense in a context in which the individual instantiations are *separated* from their essence by a 'leap' or a 'gap', and for whose crossing an act of idealization is needed. Morphological essences, on the contrary, are instantiated *in* their individuals; contrary to exact essences, they can be extracted out of these individuals by means of an abstraction (what Husserl calls the *ideative abstraction* (*ideierende Abstraktion*) in the *Logical Investigations*, and which is responsible for grasping morphological essences within their particular instances). Hence, De Muralt is wrong when he suggests the following equation in Husserl: essence = Idea = telos = ideal limit. Again, only exact essences can be understood in such a way! As we saw earlier, Derrida misreads Husserl in exactly the same way.

(b) According to De Muralt, transcendental phenomenology considers phenomena in light of their infinite approximation towards a *telos*, understood as their unreachable form of perfection. This is why De Muralt claims that "*the idea is transcendental consciousness*

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[60] "Tout objet en général est en effet l'exemple factice de son idée qui est réciproquement son exemplaire idéal." (*Ibid.,* 13) "Toutes les idées husserliennes peuvent être comprises comme des limites, limites idéales donc infinies, qui ne terminent pas réellement mais idéalement (à l'infini)." (*Ibid.,* 19) As well as: "[…] l'eidos est bien évidemment une idée et un télos." (*Ibid.,* 29)

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itself in its teleological form." [61] Now, is that correct? There is indeed a certain inherent relationship between, on the one hand, transcendental phenomenology – as the analysis of the constitution of phenomena in transcendental subjectivity – and, on the other, teleology. But everything depends on the precise understanding of this *teleology*: transcendental phenomenology is inherently teleological only under the condition that one considers teleology as the *teleological structure of fulfilment* – and not as the asymptotic approximation towards an unreachable limit or perfection. In other words, the teleology which interests transcendental phenomenology is the ordered dynamic of intentionalities and their temporal unfolding in the synthetic consciousness of unity[62].

But this does not seem to be the understanding of De Muralt. For the kind of teleology he is concerned with (and which is at the core at Husserl's alleged "exemplarism") amounts to an *asymptotic* approximation of phenomena towards their ideal form or "essence". In sum, De Muralt falsely attributes to transcendental phenomenology a (platonic) *metaphysics of essences* which considers phenomena in light of to their ideal of perfection. He therefore misreads "[...] the transcendental, [as] being identical with the idea, with the eidetic itself..."[63]. This betrays not only a misunderstanding of what phenomenological eidetics is and how it works; it also shows that De Muralt conflates

[61] "D'une manière générale donc l'idée est la conscience transcendantale elle-même dans sa forme téléologique." (Ibid., 349)

[62] A coherent interpretation of transcendental phenomenology through the different regulative ideas that teleologically prescribe various structures of fulfilment to the different ontological regions has been successfully put forth by D. Pradelle, *Par-delà la révolution copernicienne*.

[63] De Muralt, L'idée de la phénoménologie, 350.

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transcendental phenomenology with a phenomenological investigation of (Platonic) essences.

Although Derrida himself correctly distinguishes the phenomenological reduction from eidetic reduction – and thus transcendental phenomenology from a phenomenological inquiry into essences[64] – he nevertheless seems to be in line with De Muralt's interpretation of the transcendental. For as we saw in one of the entry quote of this paper, Derrida claims that consciousness becomes "transcendental consciousness" as soon as it "recognizes" itself "through the sign of the infinite" and by "the Idea's prescription"[65]. This makes perfectly sense if we take "Idea" in De Muralt's sense as the ideal form or essence, which, albeit being imperfectly instantiated in every "human transcendental consciousness"[66], nevertheless constitutes the unreachable limit that human consciousness can only approach asymptotically. Finally, in both Derrida and De Muralt, the notion of the "transcendental" becomes linked to a teleological endpoint, to a *transcendens* in the original scholastic understanding. In a footnote, Derrida says:

> If the Idea is thought here to have a transcendental sense and […] is "beyond" only compared with the *constituted* moment of transcendental subjectivity, we can observe that Husserl profoundly recuperates the original scholastic sense of the transcendental (*unum, verum, bonum*, etc., as the transcategorial of Aristotelian logic).[67]

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[64] Derrida, "Introduction", 58/68.

[65] Derrida, "Introduction", 154/140.

[66] *Ibid.,* 162/146.

[67] *Ibid.,* 162/146.

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In order to understand the Husserlian transcendental in analogy with the transcategorial *transcendens* of the scholastics, one needs to supress its original sense as an activity, a power or a performance (of constitution and genesis); one needs to equate the transcendental with an asymptotic approximation towards a telos. This is the reading, as we have seen, of De Muralt, to which Derrida fully adheres – but it is not at all the understanding of Husserl.

8. Conclusion

It has become clear that Derrida's reading pursues its own goals, different from those of Husserl. Albeit his high level of expertise and accuracy in Husserlian scholarship, Derrida's interpretation pushes Husserl's phenomenology into a rationalist direction which is difficult to corroborate. It is neither possible to reduce all forms of appearances to the performance of a "pure thinking", nor is it correct to understand both the *Erlebnisstrom* and the thing as versions of the mathematical ideality. Husserl indeed makes in all three cases reference to the Idea in the Kantian sense. But this cannot hide the fact that all cases display fundamentally different intentional dynamics, and that the Idea in the Kantian sense refers in each case to a different structure of appearing.

The centrality of the Cartesian *intellectio* in Derrida's reading of Husserl is therefore grossly identifying. It does not acknowledge the fundamental fact that Husserl's epistemology accounts for a multiplicity of ontological regions which all have their own intentional dynamics. Mathematical idealities only constitute *one* particular region. It would be wrong to ground all other regions on it.

But Derrida's main mistake is probably to have ignored the complex dynamics of fulfilment which are fundamental to the appearing of the transcendent thing and which are at the core of Husserl's understanding of the thing as being an "inadequate" but

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nonetheless "original" givenness. Derrida's attempt to reduce the appearing of the thing to a "pure thinking" fails, for he does not acknowledge that the thing's inadequateness implies a certain *Leibhaftigkeit,* as well as an original intuition and givenness.

We also saw that Derrida's reading of Husserl bears important parallels to De Muralt, whose book Derrida quotes in the "Introduction". We therefore presumed that when writing his "Introduction", Derrida was more influenced by the Swiss Neoplatonic than he actually acknowledged.

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